> weapons, which you described as “offensive”, and their crating and return to the Soviet Union.[4]

Yet, as David Coleman demonstrates in his book, *The Fourteenth Day*, neither significant diplomatic nor military activity ceased at that point.[5] The Joint Chiefs were so sceptical of Khrushchev’s promise that they recommended to the President he order a full air strike the following day, followed by an invasion, unless there was ‘irrefutable evidence’ that the missiles were being dismantled.[6]

When Khrushchev ordered General Pliyev to immediately begin dismantling the R-12 bases, his troops stopped their backbreaking efforts to bring the weapons to readiness and began the backbreaking work of dismantling the launch sites. Elsewhere, though, there was no discernible change in military dispositions. The blockade remained in effect. The Sixty-ninth Torpedo Submarine Brigade continue to play cat and mouse (or mouse and cat) with US ASW forces, who continued with their submarine surfacing procedures. US forces around the world remained at DEFCON-3 and SAC stayed at DEFCON-2, with its airborne alerted B-52s flying back and forth to their Fail-Safe points. Numbers of alerted ICBMs and bombers continued to rise. In the UK the sixtieth Thor IRBM was mated with its warhead and stood ready to fire. Bomber Command stayed at Alert Condition 3 and other measures were taken to strengthen the V-force.

So, at the operational level, there were no immediate changes in circumstances in which a concatenation of misadventure, misjudgement, and misunderstanding might still lead to inadvertent escalation. Several instances of this stand out (in addition to those involving the Soviet submarines discussed in the previous chapter). One occurred as Washington was taking in the news of Khrushchev’s announcement on 28 October. Less than a week earlier President Kennedy had declared that any nuclear missile launched from Cuba would require a full retaliatory response upon the Soviet Union. Early on the morning of Sunday, 28 October 1962 US radar operators identified a ballistic missile launching from Cuba and heading for Florida.